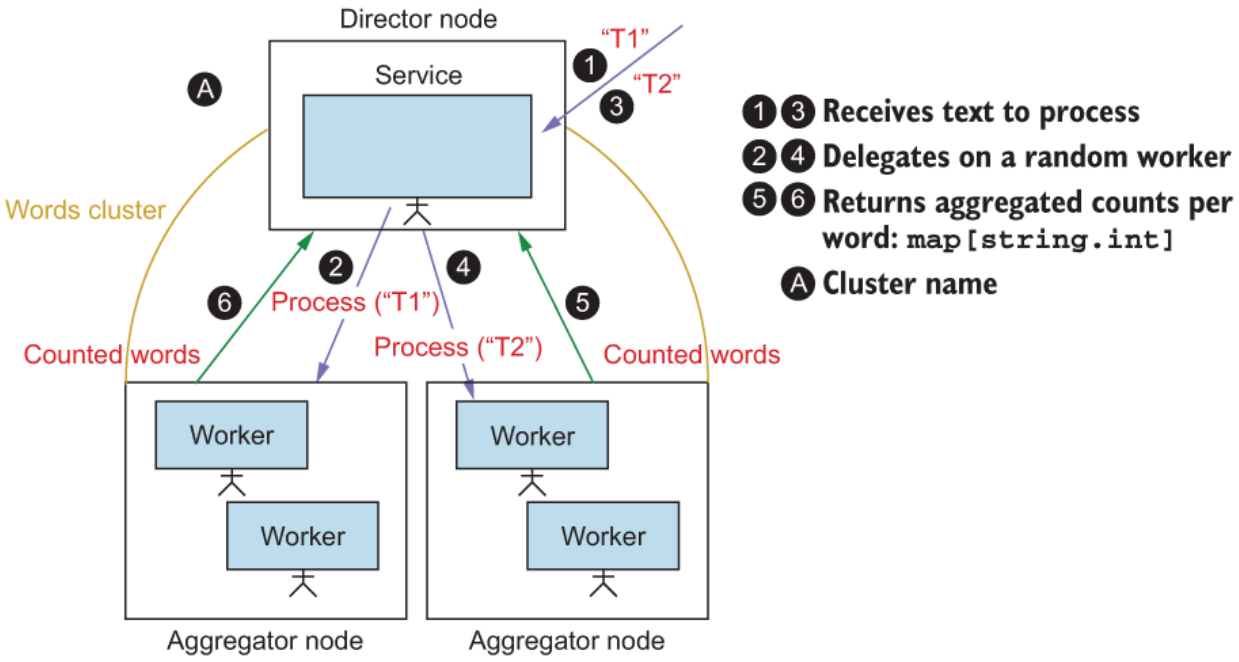


Figure 8.2 Sketch of an application that counts words

Before we get into the nitty-gritty of the application, you need to know how to create a cluster using seed nodes, how nodes become seed nodes, and how they can join and leave the cluster. In the following sections, you see how a cluster is formed and experiment with the REPL console to join and leave a simple cluster. Finally, you learn about the different states a member node can go through and how to receive notifications about those state changes.

8.2.1 Cluster membership: Joining a cluster

Like any group, a cluster needs a few "founders." Akka provides a seed node feature for this purpose. *Seed nodes* are the starting point of the cluster and serve as the first point of contact for other nodes. Nodes join the cluster by sending a `JOIN` message containing the joining node's unique address. The `Cluster` module ensures that this message is sent to one of the registered seed nodes.